Test cricket. We had scored 92–8 by the end of the first day's play and Ashish was one of the not-out batsmen. He resumed his innings on the second day but we were soon all out for 99. He was then part of our attack as we bowled New Zealand out for 94 in their first innings, before we ourselves were bowled out in our second innings for 154. Finally, when New Zealand came out to bat in the fourth innings of the match, Ashish had another bowl at them in the final moments of the day.

We discussed his feat in the dressing room and wondered if anything of the sort had happened before. A total of twenty-two wickets had fallen in a day and there wasn't much that the batsmen on either side could do in such conditions. It was disappointing for the crowd, who had come to watch a five-day game. Their only consolation was that the match was very close in the end and the home team won by four wickets.

Fighting for fitness

With both Test matches over early, I decided to spend a lot of time in the gym working on my fitness ahead of the World Cup. Sehwag was my training partner and we used to award marks. We worked on specific body parts each day and rated each other for the effort put in. We even joked that we were perhaps scoring more marks in the gym than the total runs we had scored in the series. But both Sehwag and I were confident that the effort put in would pay off sooner or later.

After the Test series was wrapped up we played a seven-match one-day series, losing 2–5. Again, most of the wickets weren't really suitable for international cricket. I did not feature in the first four matches because of an ankle injury, which I sustained in practice on the eve of the first one-dayer at Auckland. It was one of the few freakish injuries I have had in my career. I had just finished bowling a long spell to each of our batsmen when Srinath called out, 'Last ball, with four runs to win.' I picked up the ball again to bowl one final delivery at him. I had not noticed a big hole in the corner of the practice pitch and, unluckily for me, as I ran to stop Srinath's shot, my foot landed in the hole and I slumped to the ground in agony. After a frustrating couple of weeks, I eventually made a comeback in the fifth match of the series, at Wellington, and was promptly out for a duck. In fact I scored just one run in each of the next two matches and Anjali and I joked about my scores – which read 0, 1, 1 – being the dialling code for an Indian city!